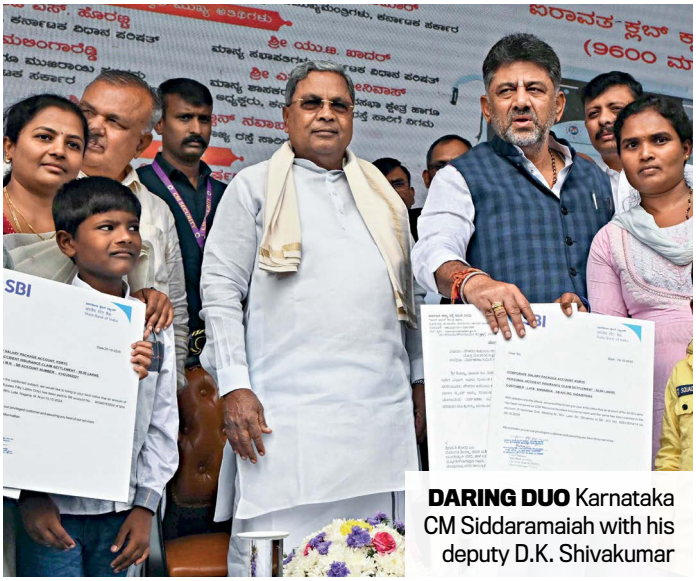
KARNATAKA

UPPER HAND FOR CONGRESS

Voters back the Grand Old Party even as CM Siddaramaiah battles graft charges

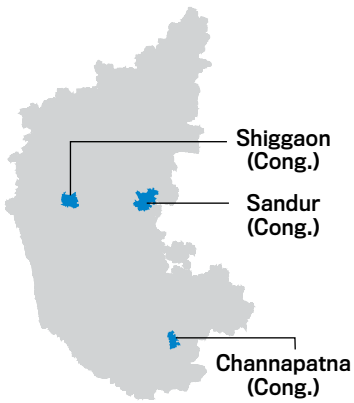
Byelections in: **3 seats** | Won by: **Cong.**



DARING DUO Karnataka CM Siddaramaiah with his deputy D.K. Shivakumar

The outcome of byelections to three seats—Channapatna, Shiggaon and Sandur—wouldn't have made any difference to the clear majority that the Congress enjoys in Karnataka's legislative assembly. But it was critical to Chief Minister Siddaramaiah, who faces an ongoing Lokayukta investigation in the Mysuru Urban Development Authority (MUDA) corruption case.

Not just that, the contest at Channapatna pitted two political heavyweights—deputy chief minister D.K. Shivakumar and Union minister H.D. Kumaraswamy—in yet another turf war in the Vokkaliga-dominated Old Mysuru region. In the parliamentary polls,



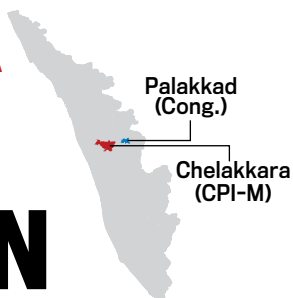
Kumaraswamy's Janata Dal (Secular), in alliance with the BJP, had handed a decisive defeat to Shivakumar's younger brother D.K. Suresh. Pulling off a coup of sorts, Shivakumar inducted and declared BJP turncoat C.P. Yogeshwar—a former minister and local Vokkaliga leader—as the Congress candidate from Channapatna, vacated by Kumaraswamy. This, along with the consolidation of Muslim votes, helped them defeat the JD(S) leader's son Nikhil by 25,413 votes.

The Congress also recorded a surprise victory in Shiggaon, where it pacified rebellious partymen to snatch the seat that had been vacated by former BJP CM Basavaraj Bommai, whose son Bharath was now in the fray. And, in Sandur, the Congress maintained its winning streak—uninterrupted since 2008. The 3-0 scoreline delivers a blow to the Opposition, leaving both the BJP and JD(S) grappling with internal discord. ■

-Ajay Sukumaran

KERALA

AN EVEN OUTCOME



It's one all for Kerala's two key alliances; BJP the biggest loser

Byelections in **2 seats** | Won by **CPI(M) 1; Cong. 1**

While the spotlight remained on Priyanka Gandhi Vadra's maiden electoral victory in Wayanad Lok Sabha seat, two key assembly bypolls in Kerala—Chelakkara and Palakkad—delivered mixed results for the state's dominant alliances.

In Chelakkara, the CPI(M)'s U.R. Pradeep retained the seat for his party, hence ensuring that the ruling Left Democratic Front (LDF) maintains its dominance with 98 legislators in the 140-member assembly. Meanwhile, in Palakkad, a Congress bastion since 2011, its candidate Rahul Mamkootathil secured a win for the United Democratic Front (UDF), which has 41 legislators.

The LDF was facing a crucial test in Chelakkara—a seat it has not lost since 1996. The win came as a big relief for Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan, who credited it to continued public confidence in the eight-year-old LDF government.

For the BJP, the results have come as a big disappointment as it hoped to win Palakkad, where the saffron party has been the runner-up since 2016. But despite running a high-octane campaign, it was unable to dislodge the Congress and suffered a substantial loss in its vote share. ■

-Jeemon Jacob